



Above *Solyanka* is a rich mix of vegetables and meat or fish, enriched with a dash of sour cream

Left Legend has it that St. Basil's Cathedral, completed in 1561, was so beautiful that Ivan the Terrible ordered the architect to be killed, so he could not build its equal elsewhere



Above *Worker and Collective Farmer* (1937) is an iconic Soviet-era sculpture that is now located at an entrance to the All-Russian Exhibition Center

Russian Vodka

"Drinking is the joy of the Russians. We cannot live without it." So said the 10th-century Prince Vladimir, rejecting Islam as the state religion in favor of Christianity, which allowed the drinking of vodka. Over a millennium later, vodka remains central to Russian life – as much a curse as a joy, being the prime cause of falling life expectancy in Russian men. Russians seldom go for mixers, but never drink vodka without eating (if only bread). Vodka may be infused with lemon (*limonnaya*), hot peppers (*pertsovka*), bison-grass (*zubrovka*), juniper berries, cloves (*okhotnitchaya*), or other flavorings. Russians adore elaborate toasts, but you can get by with "Za zdorovye!" ("To health!").

The Best Places to Eat Solyanka

Café Pushkin expensive

Named after the Romantic poet, whose ill-starred wedding occurred in the vicinity, this establishment would have delighted him. People gape as they enter the building, a former pharmacy with huge windows and rich, Biedermeier-style fittings; its upper floors formed part of an aristocrat's home in the 1820s. The apothecary prepared drugs in the cellar, which is now furnished like a mad scientist's laboratory, with Bunsen burners, a Morse telegraph, and other retro gadgetry. The first floor is grander, with a sumptuously paneled library of rare editions and a ballroom built for an ancestor of the composer Rimsky-Korsakov, which now serves as the VIP dining room. During the summer, there's also a rooftop terrace café. Each floor has a different menu – though all feature a rich meat *solyanka* that leaves just enough room for a main course. You can choose between medieval specialties such as baked sterlet (a small sturgeon) in caviar sauce or pike head stuffed with fish and apple *confit*, or Frenchified dishes such as crab salad with quail eggs and basil-and-raspberry mayonnaise. As befits the clientele of oligarchs, movie stars, and politicians, the wine list is princely.

Tverskoy bulvar 26A, Moscow; open 24 hours daily; www.cafe-pushkin.ru/en

Also in Moscow

Solyanka can be found in the humblest cafés, but visitors to Moscow usually prefer somewhere with a touch of style or sheer oddity. **Shield and Sword** (+7 495 222 4446; *inexpensive*) is a KGB-themed place whose dining room contains a replica of the statue of "Iron Felix" Dzerzhinsky that once stood outside the Lubyanka headquarters of the secret police, which he founded. Its Soviet-style menu includes *solyanka*, *pelmeni* (Russian ravioli), and chicken Kiev. Many dishes come with a shot of vodka. Alternatively, check out **Solyanka** (<http://s-11.ru/english>; *moderate*), a hip restaurant, bar, club, and boutique, named after the street on which it stands (which once led to the Royal Salt Yard) rather than the dish (which only features on its lunchtime menu on Wednesdays). *Solyanka* offers plenty of alternatives to Russian food, from *tom yam* soup and chicken curry to Mediterranean salads and pasta dishes. There are lines outside on weekends, when DJs play hip-hop until 6:00 AM.

Also in Russia

In St. Petersburg, you can enjoy *solyanka* at the **Café Sunduk** (www.cafesunduk.ru; *inexpensive*), a funky art-café that has live Spanish, blues, or jazz music.